Check for updates

Received: 13 July 2024 | Accepted: 14 February 2025

DOI: 10.1111/ijsw.70005

REVIEW ARTICLE

INTERNATIONAL JOURNAL OF SOCIAL WELFARE

A systematic integrative review of international policies for women experiencing homelessness

Alba Galán-Sanantonio | **Mercedes Botija** | **Ángela Carbonell**

Department of Social Work and Social Services, Universitat de València, Valencia, Spain

Correspondence
Mercedes Botija, Social Work and Social Services Department, Tarongers Avenue, 4B.Office 2 D21, Universitat de València, 46021 Valencia, Spain.
Email: mercedes.botija@uv.es

Funding information
Generalitat Valenciana; European Social Fund, Grant/Award Number: CIACIF 2021/176

Abstract

This systematic review evaluates policies, programmes and strategies from the literature targeting homeless or at-risk women, severely affected by gender and class inequality. Following PRISMA guidelines (2020), the review focused on English, Spanish and Portuguese articles from the past 20 years, excluding documents without full-text access. Grey literature was also included to reduce bias. The search concluded on 31 May 2023, covering Web of Science, PubMed, Scopus and Cochrane, resulting in 40 included documents (31 articles, two book chapters and seven reports). Thematic analysis identified five categories: gender-blind homeless policies, challenges in policies on homelessness among women, preventive programmes, emergency aid and long-term housing services. The findings emphasise the need for gender-specific and intersectional policies and the inclusion of homeless women in policy development. Despite limitations like potential publication bias and limited geographical representation, this study highlights the challenges faced by homeless women and recommends policy approaches to address their needs.

KEYWORDS

gender, homeless women, homelessness, policies, welfare

INTRODUCTION

Homelessness is a multifaceted issue impacting economic, social and health dimensions on a global scale (Mitchell et al., 2023).

Despite the multiple definitions of homelessness, an increasing consensus has recently existed with regard to the one provided by FEANTSA (2007), which defines a person as being homeless when they lack a stable, safe and adequate place of residence. Homelessness emerges as a result of a complex interplay of risk factors encompassing individual, social and structural dimensions (Mayock et al., 2015a).

Although it is a global issue, certain inherent challenges and limitations arise when attempting to accurately measure homelessness (Busch-Geertsema et al., 2010). Hidden homelessness is one of these difficulties. It refers to individuals who, despite being homeless, are not included in statistical counts due to the data collection measures used. This disproportionately affects homeless women, since they often receive informal support and may remain in situations of gender-based violence before seeking assistance from homeless services or staying on the streets (Bretherton & Pleace, 2018).

Thus, as a social problem, homelessness is not exempt from gender disparities, and the literature reveals the existence of an increasing number of homeless women over recent decades, due to the phenomenon known as the feminisation of poverty (Alonso et al., 2020).

In addition to depriving individuals of their right to housing, homelessness also poses barriers to accessing

This is an open access article under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution License, which permits use, distribution and reproduction in any medium, provided the original work is properly cited.
© 2025 The Author(s). *International Journal of Social Welfare* published by Akademikerförbundet SSR (ASSR) and John Wiley & Sons Ltd.

other fundamental rights, including employment and healthcare (Lim et al., 2002). Homeless individuals typically experience higher rates of both physical and mental health problems as compared to the general population. These problems are associated with elevated mortality rates (Lima et al., 2020) and they may be even more pronounced in homeless women, especially in terms of mental health issues (Rodriguez-Moreno et al., 2020; Wolf et al., 2016). Furthermore, homeless women are at higher risk for intimate partner violence, domestic violence and sexual violence, both before and after losing their homes (Mayock et al., 2015b; Milaney et al., 2020; Nardes & Giongo, 2021; Shinn, 2010). Consequently, female homelessness is a critically important social issue that is deeply rooted in gender inequality and economic disparities. It impacts not only the health and well-being of women but also has major implications for them and their potential families (Bimpson et al., 2020).

Despite the seriousness of homelessness among women, this issue remains largely invisible in the policies of many countries (Yohannes et al., 2023). In this context, social policies are essential to ensure that homeless individuals have access to critical services such as housing, healthcare and social support, as well as to prevent homelessness and alleviate its consequences (Busch-Geertsema et al., 2010; Reppond & Bullock, 2018).

Over recent years, there has been a growing interest in researching homelessness, with feminist efforts specifically aimed at raising awareness of the situation of homeless women (Mayock & Bretherton, 2016; O'Brien, 2023). Studies on homeless women have highlighted the distinct causes, consequences and experiences compared to homeless men, emphasising that women face greater vulnerability and a heightened need for social attention (Bretherton & Mayock, 2021). Therefore, Minnery and Greenhalgh (2007) highlighted the need to adjust homelessness policies, which have historically focused on White men, to address evolving forms of homelessness, including those experienced by women. Furthermore, Mostowska (2021) emphasises the importance of researching responses to homelessness among women and investigating potential gender-specific impacts of homelessness policies. Nevertheless, to the best of our knowledge, few studies have specifically examined policies to address homelessness among women. Furthermore, no systematic review has been undertaken on this specific subject.

This study addresses which specific policies, programmes and strategies for homeless or at-risk women are discussed in the academic literature and how they are addressed. The aim is to identify these policies, programmes and strategies and assess their impact on women and the challenges they face within the policy context. A systematic review of the literature has been conducted to achieve this.

Key Practitioner Message

1. The literature shows that homeless women, often under-represented due to hidden homelessness, face greater challenges than men.
2. This article underscores the need for a gender perspective in social welfare policies and programmes addressing homelessness, traditionally designed for men.
3. Understanding the impact of homelessness policies on women is crucial for creating effective, evidence-based solutions.

MATERIALS AND METHODS

Various types of literature reviews exist, but the integrative systematic review was selected as the most suitable for this topic. It combines findings from diverse sources, including quantitative, qualitative and other reviews (Cronin & George, 2020). These reviews integrate results into a new mixed-methods synthesis, providing a broader understanding of the examined phenomenon (Torraco, 2016). Research by Fraser et al. (2021) indicates that a comprehensive understanding of the issue of women's homelessness requires both quantitative and qualitative research. Furthermore, this type of review is particularly appropriate when aiming to effectively inform public policies (Cronin & George, 2020).

The systematic review was carried out based on the PRISMA 2020 (Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic Reviews and Meta-Analyses) guidelines (Page et al., 2021). The completed checklist is in Table A1. The PRISMA 2020 for Abstracts Checklist (Page et al., 2021) is also available in Table A2.

Search strategy and information sources

Scientific articles were searched in the following databases: Web of Science, Scopus, Pubmed and Cochrane. These databases were selected based on the area of knowledge under study.

The search strategy was formulated based on a review of the literature on conducting systematic reviews, using synonyms and combining Boolean operators and truncations to identify the most relevant evidence (Atkinson & Cipriani, 2018; Bramer et al., 2018; Eriksen & Frandsen, 2018). Initial exploratory searches were conducted to establish appropriate search terms. Thus, a systematic search was conducted in the databases for the following terms:

14682397, 2025, 2, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/ijsw.70005, Wiley Online Library on [08/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

(Homeless* OR houseless* OR "living rough" OR "no fixed abode" OR "roofless" OR "sleeping rough") AND ("policies" OR "policy" OR "welfare benefits" OR "welfare state") AND ("women" OR "female" OR "gender" OR "sex" OR "woman").

Articles published between 1 January 2003 and 31 May 2023 were searched.

Subsequently, manual searches for grey literature were carried out on specific government policy websites related to homelessness, as well as in the references of the included studies.

After an initial phase of title and abstract screening, followed by an assessment based on inclusion and exclusion criteria, we proceeded with a comprehensive search and the reading of full texts. Articles meeting the established criteria underwent quality assessment prior to their inclusion in the review.

Eligibility criteria

Eligible articles focused on policies concerning homeless or at-risk women and evaluated the effects of public policies related to homelessness among women. Documents addressing preventive policies for vulnerable women that explicitly discussed homelessness were also included. Regarding language, we considered articles written in English, Spanish or Portuguese. Only papers published over the past two decades were considered for this review.

The PRISMA statement permits grey literature in reviews, though its use in systematic reviews is debated. We included it in this investigation to enhance understanding and reduce bias. Grey literature, comprising works not usually indexed in traditional databases, provides valuable information that improves the comprehensiveness and balance of the analysis (Paez, 2017). Additionally, critical documents analysing public policies may reside within the realm of grey literature, providing valuable insight and perspectives for the research.

Articles lacking full-text access were excluded from the review.

Data extraction and synthesis

The documents were analysed to extract information on document type, authorship, country of research, published journal, journal indexing, study design and sample.

Thematic Analysis, as advocated by Minayo (2004), was employed, involving three phases. Firstly, categories and subcategories were identified from the data for classification. Secondly, the iterative process revisited the data to ensure comprehensive and accurate theme identification using an inductive approach, allowing patterns to emerge naturally (Braun & Clarke, 2006). Lastly, conclusions were drawn, organising and describing the data to interpret various dimensions related to the research topic, facilitated by the MAXQDA (2020) tool.

Quality assessment

To ensure the quality of the systematic review and minimise biases, we evaluated the studies selected for inclusion using appropriate assessment tools tailored to their respective methodologies.

For articles employing qualitative methodology, we utilised the 10-item Critical Appraisal Skills Programme (CASP) for Qualitative Research (CASP, 2023a), where each item required a response of 'Yes', 'Can't tell' or 'No'. Review articles were evaluated using the 10-item CASP for Reviews tool (CASP, 2023b).

For articles employing mixed methods, the 2018 version of the Mixed Methods Appraisal Tool (MMAT) was used (Hong et al., 2018). For articles combining qualitative and review methodologies ($n = 2$), dual evaluations were conducted using CASP for Reviews and CASP for Qualitative Articles, as the MMAT is unsuitable for reviews or theoretical studies. Quantitative articles were analysed using the appropriate MMAT section for non-randomised or descriptive quantitative articles, each containing seven items.

Options for each question were 'Yes', 'Can't tell' or 'No'. To determine the quality level, we calculated the ratio of affirmative responses to the total number of questions in each respective tool. The scores were categorised into three quality levels: low (0–3 points), moderate (4–7 points) and high (8–10 points).

The literature search, study selection, data extraction, narrative analysis and quality assessment were independently conducted by two authors (AG, MB). Disagreements were resolved through discussion with a third author (AC).

FINDINGS

Initially, 848 records were found in the databases. After deduplication ($n = 299$), an initial review assessed titles and abstracts. Those not meeting the inclusion criteria according to the abstracts were excluded ($n = 450$). Subsequently, the full text of the remaining documents ($n = 89$) was found and reviewed, with 32 of these meeting the thematic criteria. Additional documents were

14682397, 2025, 2, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/ijsw.70005, Wiley Online Library on [08/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

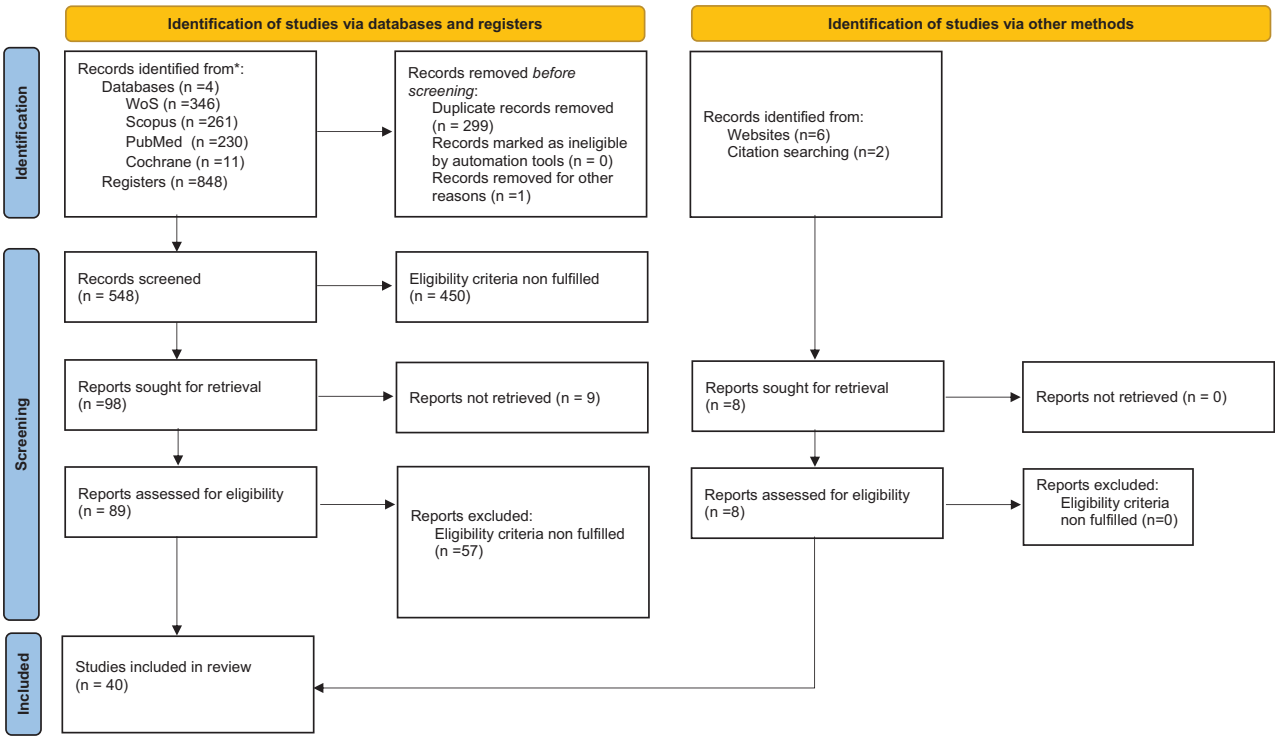

FIGURE 1 PRISMA 2020 flow diagram.

identified through referenced bibliographies (2) and web searching (6). Thirty-one articles underwent quality assessment. None were excluded during this process. Consequently, 40 documents were included in the review. Figure 1 details this selection process.

Description of the included studies

Table 1 presents a concise overview of details from the selected articles. Upon categorising the selected documents based on their study type, 31 scientific articles were published in high-impact journals, two book chapters and seven reports. The 31 articles analysed were primarily from journals indexed in the Journal Citation Reports (JCR), making up 83.37% of the total. An additional 16.13% of the articles were sourced from journals indexed in the Scimago Journal Rank (SJR).

Regarding methodologies, the studies relied on diverse approaches. Qualitative research was predominant (42.5%), followed by review studies (40%) and quantitative studies (10%). A smaller portion of the works used mixed methods (2.5%), combining both qualitative and quantitative approaches. Some studies utilised both qualitative and review methodologies (5%).

All documents, except two in Portuguese, were in English. Geographically, research findings were sourced globally: North America constituted 32.5%, Europe 30%, Oceania 27.5%, South America 5%, Asia 2.5% and Africa 2.5%.

After a quality assessment of the 31 articles, it was found that 76.67% were of high methodological quality and the remaining 23.33% were of moderate quality. Quality assessments for each study can be found in Tables A3 and A4.

The book chapters underwent peer review.

An analysis of homelessness policies through a gender lens: Insights from the literature

Based on the data analysis, five main categories were identified. These categories were further subdivided into 21 subcategories, as illustrated in Table 2.

Gender-blind and stigmatising homeless policies

Homelessness policies evolved in the 1970s in various welfare states, focusing mainly on men (Vamstad et al., 2022). For instance, O'Brien (2023) notes that in Australia, while homeless women were provided access to shelters and charity houses, the assistance they received was notably less than the institutional support

14682397, 2025, 2, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/ijsw.70005, Wiley Online Library on [08/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

TABLE 1 Overview of methodological and quality attributes in the included studies.

Author and year	Journal	Indexation	Country	Study design	Sample	Quality	Document type
Baker et al. (2010)	Aggression and violent behaviour	JCR	US	Review		High	Article
Benbow et al. (2016)	Canadian Journal of Nursing Research	JCR	Canada	Qualitative and Review	26 homeless mothers and 15 service providers	High High	Article
Bimpson et al. (2020)	Housing Studies	JCR	UK	Qualitative	26 homeless mothers	High	Article
Bimpson et al. (2021)			UK	Review			Report
Blunden and Flanagan (2022)	Housing Studies	JCR	Australia	Qualitative	28 women who had to leave their homes due to domestic and family violence	High	Article
Bretherton et al. (2016)			Ireland	Review			Book chapter
Bretherton and Mayock (2021)			UK	Review			Report
Bullen (2021)	Housing Studies	JCR	Australia	Qualitative	10 women with chronic homelessness experiences and nine service providers	High	Article
Bullock et al. (2020)	Journal of Social Issues	JCR	US	Qualitative	46 currently and formerly homeless mothers	High	Article
Cheng and Kelly (2008)	Gender Medicine	JCR	US	Quantitative	4502 men and 2727 women who were homeless and had serious mental illness issues	High	Article
Cramer (2005)	Housing Studies	JCR	UK	Qualitative	11 single homeless women, 23 single men, 12 families (five couples with children, four lone mothers, two lone fathers and one pregnant woman) and 38 housing officers.	High	Article
Da Costa et al. (2015)	Saúde e Sociedade	JCR	Brazil	Qualitative	13 homeless women who were pregnant or with children under two.	High	Article
Flanagan et al. (2019)			Australia	Review			Report
Fraser et al. (2021)	SSM—Population Health	JCR	New Zealand	Quantitative	210 women and 180 men in the Housing First Programme	High	Article
Jones and Wendt (2022)	Australian Social Work	JCR	Australia	Qualitative and Review	Three academic experts and 21 practitioners	High High	Article
Keefe & Hahn, 2020	Violence against women	JCR	US	Review		High	Article
Klodawsky (2009)	Urban Geography	JCR	Canada	Review		High	Article
Löfstrand and Quilgars (2016)			Ireland	Review			Book chapter

(Continues)

14682397, 2025, 2, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/ijsw.70005, Wiley Online Library on [08/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

TABLE 1 (Continued)

Author and year	Journal	Indexation	Country	Study design	Sample	Quality	Document type
Milaney et al. (2020)	Societies	SJR	Canada	Qualitative	18 new mothers with recent homelessness experiences and 16 service providers	High	Article
Mostowska and Dębska (2020)	Journal of Gender Studies	JCR	Poland	Qualitative	44 homeless women and 40 experts	High	Article
Mostowska (2021)	Critical Housing Analysis	SJR	Poland	Review		High	Article
Murray (2011)	Australian Social Work	JCR	Australia	Qualitative	29 women who had experienced violence during homelessness	High	Article
Nardes and Giongo (2021)	Revista Estudos Feministas	SJR	Brazil	Qualitative	10 women living rough	High	Article
Netto et al. (2009)	Social Policy and Administration	JCR	UK	Mixed methods	Eight ethnic minority women who had been homeless in Scotland, three women were forced to leave their homes due to domestic violence, 12 homelessness service providers and six service users	High	Article
O'Brien (2023)	Australian Feminist Studies	JCR	Australia	Review		Moderate	Article
Oudshoorn et al. (2018)	Journal of Social Inclusion	JCR	Canada	Qualitative		High	Article
Perri and O'Campo (2021)	Health Promotion International	JCR	Canada	Review		High	Article
Pleace (2016)			UK	Review			Report
Vigiola et al. (2022)	Urban Policy and Research	JCR	Australia	Qualitative	Leaders of DF-focused service and housing providers	High	Article
Reeve and Bimpson (2020)			UK	Review			Report
Schmidt et al. (2015)	International Journal of Circumpolar Health	JCR	Canada	Qualitative	61 homeless women	High	Article
Sisco (2017)	Journal of Women, Politics and Policy	JCR	US	Quantitative	115 congressional bills	High	Article
Song (2008)	Feminist review	JCR	South Korea	Qualitative	Ethnographic study	Moderate	Article
Spinney and Blandy (2011)			Australia	Review			Report
Spinney (2012)			Australia	Review			Report
Theobald et al. (2023)	Australian Social Work	JCR	Australia	Qualitative	41 stakeholders and 14 women who had experienced pregnancy during homelessness	High	Article

14682397, 2025, 2, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/ijsw.70005, Wiley Online Library on [08/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

TABLE 1 (Continued)

Author and year	Journal	Indexation	Country	Study design	Sample	Quality	Document type
Vamstad et al. (2022)	Nordic Social Work Research	SJR	Sweden	Qualitative	26 homeless women	High	Article
Willie et al. (2021)	Social Science and Medicine	JCR	US	Quantitative	3988 women and 2589 men survivors of IPV	High	Article
Yakubovich and Maki (2021)	Violence Against Women	JCR	Canada	Review		High	Article
Yohannes et al. (2023)	International Journal for Equity in Health	SJR	Ethiopia	Qualitative	34 participants from organisations working with homeless people	High	Article

Abbreviations: JCR, Journal Citation Reports; SJR, Scimago Journal Rank.

TABLE 2 Thematic categories and subcategories.

Categories	Subcategories
1. Gender-blind and stigmatising homeless policies	Gender disparities in homeless policies
	Stigmatisation of homeless women
	Housing challenges for women surviving gender-based violence
	Struggles for homeless mothers
	Gender differences in health and mental health
2. Barriers and challenges in addressing homelessness among women in welfare states	Lack of international data
	Definitional challenges
	Hidden homelessness
	Administrative barriers
	A Gap in Intersectionality Awareness
3. Preventive policies and programmes	Eviction defence policies
	Stay-at-home programmes for violence survivors
	Rapid rehousing
4. Emergency shelter and financial support	Shelter for homeless women
	Shelter for violence survivors
	Emergency motels
	Private rental subsidies
5. Long-term housing and service provision	Public housing
	Transitional housing
	Continuum of care
	Housing first

extended to homeless men. A study by Mostowska and Dębska (2020) highlights that in many European countries, housing systems, despite professing neutrality, have been constructed on a male-breadwinner model, which tends to overlook the specific needs of women. Bullock et al. (2020) suggest that this implies gender-neutral programmes could potentially lean towards privileging more advantaged groups, potentially leaving women without the requisite attention and support. Song's (2008) policy analysis in South Korea reveals how gender dynamics and dominant economic ideologies have influenced welfare policies. Unequal resource allocation and gender stereotypes may lead to certain groups, such as homeless women, being labelled as 'undeserving' welfare recipients, marginalising or excluding them from benefits and protection.

The study by Sisco (2017), analysing congressional bills in the United States, concluded that while women have been receiving more political attention over recent decades, this does not tend to translate into political actions or funding.

Furthermore, certain policies may inadvertently stigmatise women and mothers experiencing homelessness (Bimpson et al., 2020), impeding their progress and potentially pushing them into or obstructing their journey out of homelessness (Nardes & Giongo, 2021; Perri & O'Campo, 2021). These challenges may be exacerbated by nuisance laws, eviction policies and hygienist measures targeting the homeless.

Literature indicates that women are more likely to face eviction than men, and if the specific vulnerabilities faced by these women are not considered, these policies may further worsen their conditions (Desmond, 2014; Desmond & Valdez, 2012; Willie et al., 2021). Conversely, Willie et al. (2021) indicate that protective measures against these policies can have a more significant protective effect on women's mental health than on men's.

Over recent decades, there has been a heightened political focus on women as victims of violence internationally. Numerous studies have revealed a strong link

14682397, 2025, 2, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/ijsw.70005, Wiley Online Library on [08/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

between women experiencing homelessness and their exposure to violence, both before and after becoming homeless (Baker et al., 2010; Bimpson et al., 2020; Keefe & Hahn, 2020; Milaney et al., 2020; Murray, 2011; O'Brien, 2023; Willie et al., 2021). An example is the HEARTH Act enacted in the United States in 2009, which acknowledges victims of violence against women as a vulnerable subgroup of the homeless population. This legislation advocates for tailored services, including shelters and housing programmes for survivors (Keefe & Hahn, 2020).

Despite the recent increase in political attention to violence against women in several countries, housing provision takes a secondary role when addressing intimate partner and family violence (Bimpson et al., 2021). For instance, in Australia, while survivor women often receive priority access to assistance or public housing, Flanagan et al. (2019) have shown that a notable gap exists in initiatives addressing the scarcity of affordable housing for vulnerable women. Furthermore, policies tackling this issue may suffer from insufficient resources, potentially pressuring survivors to maintain their relationships with abusers or risk homelessness, as noted in studies from Canada (Benbow et al., 2016) and the United Kingdom (Bimpson et al., 2020).

Normally, in most European countries, more support is offered to pregnant mothers or those with children, as indicated in the studies by Bretherton et al. (2016) and Bretherton and Mayock (2021), as well as in Australia according to the study by Theobald et al. (2023). However, child protection policies may fall short in addressing the specific needs of mothers. While mothers with children receive preferential treatment in shelters and public housing, they face heightened demands and scrutiny regarding their parenting abilities, as highlighted by Bimpson et al. (2020) in the United Kingdom. The separation of homeless mothers from their children is a common occurrence, sometimes related to misconceptions associating poverty or violence with inadequate motherhood (Bimpson et al., 2020). This separation may adversely affect the mothers' access to housing, leaving them in vulnerable situations (Reeve & Bimpson, 2020). Moreover, once children are removed, mothers may lose potential preferences in accessing programmes and resources, as discussed by Löfstrand and Quilgars (2016) and Flanagan et al. (2019). Shelter restrictions not considering the needs of these mothers may lead to family separation or create obstacles to accessible housing for pregnant women or mothers, as revealed by Theobald et al. (2023).

Health-related gender disparities are another aspect that should be addressed in homelessness policies, as evidenced by various studies that have found that women are especially vulnerable to physical health and mental health issues (Cheng & Kelly, 2008; Yohannes et al., 2023). Milaney et al. (2020) highlighted the specific issues of pregnancies, unsafe abortions and more frequent traumatic situations among homeless women. In a study conducted in Brazil by Da Costa et al. (2015), it was reported that homeless women faced greater difficulties in accessing healthcare services. Another investigation in Ethiopia by Yohannes et al. (2023) found that homeless women had limited access to sexual health resources.

Similarly, in a study carried out in Brazil by Nardes and Giongo (2021), the lack of specific mental health resources and addiction treatment programmes tailored to homeless women was highlighted. Some studies have suggested that the failure to address these gender-specific needs in health and mental health programmes or policies could hinder healthcare interventions and worsen their condition (Murray, 2011; Perri & O'Campo, 2021).

Barriers and challenges in addressing homelessness among women in welfare systems

Deficiencies in welfare systems often contribute to homelessness in both men and women. Nevertheless, women may encounter greater obstacles compared to men, mainly due to gender wage gaps, victimisation experiences, increased discrimination and stigma (Bullock et al., 2020).

Comparing the effectiveness of international welfare state policies in reducing the number of homeless women presents considerable challenges, mainly due to the lack of reliable and comparable cross-country data (Bretherton et al., 2016). Hence, it is difficult to conclusively demonstrate whether countries with greater social protection have fewer homeless women (Bretherton & Mayock, 2021). Accurately enumerating homeless women is even more complex than counting their male counterparts, since they frequently experience less visible forms of homelessness (Bretherton et al., 2016).

Different welfare systems face diverse challenges when addressing homelessness, one of which is the absence of a shared conceptual framework for defining female homelessness, even within the same state. This results in inconsistencies in how certain services identify and categorise women without stable and permanent housing. Some studies have indicated that victims of gender-based violence residing in specific shelters (Keefe & Hahn, 2020; Yakubovich & Maki, 2021), sex workers living at their workplace due to a lack of resources and women leaving state institutions without alternative housing options are often not recognised as homeless women (Mostowska & Dębska, 2020).

14682397, 2025, 2, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/ijsw.70005, Wiley Online Library on [08/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

The literature indicates that women may be less connected to welfare systems than men. Female homelessness is typically concealed, as women often rely on informal support before resorting to public services, which are considered a last option when no alternatives remain (Bretherton et al., 2016; Netto et al., 2009). Strict rules in some shelters, including the requirement to share rooms with men, may deter women from seeking assistance from homeless shelters or social services. Privacy and safety concerns may further discourage them from accessing these resources, leaving them vulnerable on the streets or relying on informal support networks (Schmidt et al., 2015).

Moreover, administrative hurdles may exist, since homeless women often encounter institutional mismatches when directed between various local authority offices or street-level health and welfare providers due to their lack of permanent residence (Vamstad et al., 2022). This situation is more prevalent among homeless women than among men, especially in the case of female immigrants (Bretherton et al., 2016).

Homeless women have highlighted the challenge of deficient information and coordination among various welfare state institutions and services for women, hindering their access to crucial services, including healthcare (Nardes & Giongo, 2021; Schmidt et al., 2015; Vamstad et al., 2022). Another impediment associated with welfare systems is their inadequacy in effectively addressing various issues such as mental health concerns, victimisation and substance abuse, especially when considering the specific challenges faced by homeless women. Understanding how different dimensions of exclusion may intersect and mutually influence one another, known as intersectionality (Mostowska & Dębska, 2020), is crucial in the case of homeless women, given that they frequently experience compounded forms of discrimination and marginalisation due to their gender, socio-economic status and other intersecting factors.

This intersection of dimensions, including gender, class, race, age, migration and disability, among others, creates substantial obstacles to housing access for women (Bullock et al., 2020; O'Brien, 2023; Willie et al., 2021). Analysing homelessness policies through an intersectionality perspective emphasises their failure to acknowledge overlapping categories of exclusion, complicating policy implementation due to the presence of diverse inequality hierarchies (Bullock et al., 2020).

Preventive policies

Studies conducted in the United Kingdom (Netto et al., 2009) and Australia (Murray, 2011) have suggested that the adoption of preventive policies has shown promising outcomes in tackling homelessness among women. However, further comprehensive assessments are required to better understand the extent of these changes.

Examples of preventive measures for women at risk of homelessness include eviction defence policies and support programmes designed to help victims of gender-based violence remain in their homes.

Eviction defence policies often extend to survivors of gender-based violence. Research has underscored that evictions primarily affect women (Willie et al., 2021), many of whom are victims of violence. In the United States, these policies help mitigate the risk of homelessness and have been shown to reduce biopsychosocial stress among survivors of violence (Willie et al., 2021). In certain countries, laws have been directed at assisting victims of violence against women, incorporating protective measures related to housing. In the United States, the 2005 Violence Against Women Act (VAWA) prohibits evictions for female victims of gender-based violence, although it does not include victims of sexual violence (Keefe & Hahn, 2020). Studies by Willie et al. (2021) and Baker et al. (2010) have identified barriers to access to these policies, particularly for female immigrants, those with criminal records or women within the private housing sector.

Evidence from the literature has suggested that women often leave home due to gender-based violence, resulting in possible housing instability (Mostowska & Dębska, 2020). In response to this situation, programmes and policies have been developed internationally to help women stay in their homes, preserving social networks, children's well-being and access to local services, and reducing the risk of homelessness and trauma (Breckenridge et al., 2016; Jones & Wendt, 2022; Spinney, 2012). These programmes include safety measures, psychosocial and health support (Perri & O'Campo, 2021), such as 'Keeping Women Safe in their Homes' (Australian Government Department of Social Services, 2021; Quintana Vigiola et al., 2022), 'Safe at Home' (SAH) in the United Kingdom and Australia, Bega Staying Home Leaving Violence model in New South Wales, Australia (Spinney & Blandy, 2011) and Sanctuary in England (Netto et al., 2009; Reeve & Bimpson, 2020). Despite limited evaluations (Netto et al., 2009), the study by Spinney and Blandy (2011) suggests that these interventions may not suit all women given the potential danger or preferences based on feeling unsafe or prior traumatic experiences. Therefore, Jones and Wendt (2022) argue that alternative housing options need to be available.

Rapid Rehousing refers to policies and programmes preventing individuals in vulnerable situations from

14682397, 2025, 2, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/ijsw.70005, Wiley Online Library on [08/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

losing their housing or swiftly providing them with a permanent alternative, aimed at minimising shelter time (Keefe & Hahn, 2020). It is particularly beneficial for women, especially survivors of violence, as it includes measures such as helping them remain in their homes, offering financial support, housing assistance, mental health services, addiction support and job search aid. Some evaluations in the United States have revealed positive outcomes for women in increased housing stability; long-term effects related to rising rental costs, however, are not fully considered in these assessments (Byrne et al., 2016; Katz et al., 2017; Keefe & Hahn, 2020).

The studies by Spinney and Blandy in Australia (2021) and Perri and O'Campo in Canada (2021) propose that to ensure comprehensive and high-quality care, these programmes require extensive collaboration and coordination between various governmental and non-governmental organisations. They also suggest that the professionals involved should be well-versed in addressing gender-based violence.

Emergency shelter and financial support

Emergency accommodations or crisis shelters can be vital for homeless women, especially those who have survived violence and need to quickly leave their homes (Netto et al., 2009; O'Brien, 2023). However, in Australia, Quintana Vigiola et al. (2022) found that a significant budget is often delegated to these shelters rather than more enduring housing solutions, potentially prolonging what was intended to be a temporary solution due to a lack of alternative housing options. Examined through a gender-specific lens, O'Brien (2023) highlights that emergency shelters in Australia have certain drawbacks for women, as they are often not designed with a gender perspective.

Studies by Baker et al. in the United States (2010) and Mostowska and Dębska in Poland (2020) have highlighted that shelters can be categorised into two types: those for homeless people in general and those specifically for survivors of intimate partner violence. This categorisation could result in survivors who do not have permanent housing not being recognised as homeless women. Furthermore, women who are not accepted by services for survivors of violence may end up in general homeless shelters, which often lack specific interventions addressing violence. These general shelters also tend to offer lower security levels compared to shelters designed for survivors of violence. Studies examining shelters in the United Kingdom (Bretherton et al., 2016) and Brazil (Nardes & Giongo, 2021) have suggested that the limited capacity of homeless shelters is more challenging for women and transgender women. This can lead to shared rooms and frequently inadequate staff training regarding gender issues.

Another crisis accommodation involves the use of motels, where domestic violence service providers collaborate with motels to temporarily house women or families when shelters are full (Baker et al., 2010). Studies in the United Kingdom have highlighted the potential risks arising here, especially for women who have survived violence or have children (Bimpson et al., 2020; Cramer, 2005).

Financial assistance during emergencies attempts to broaden housing choices for women, especially survivors of violence, mitigating political pressures associated with social housing waiting lists. Programmes such as 'flexible funding' in the United States and the United Kingdom exemplify this approach. However, rental subsidies dependent on the private market often face challenges due to neoliberalism's impact on the housing market, exacerbating inequalities and impeding equitable access to housing and support services (Keefe & Hahn, 2020). High rental prices hinder the individuals' ability to access and maintain housing. This access may prove even more challenging for women due to economic inequalities. Gender discrimination from housing providers may further complicate matters for women who are grappling with housing stability issues or who have endured violence. Moreover, gender bias may intersect with other forms of discrimination, such as racial prejudice, thereby intensifying inequalities in housing (Blunden & Flanagan, 2022; Flanagan et al., 2019). Even with rental subsidies targeted at women at risk, affordability challenges may force them to relocate, often far from their established social networks, which have proven especially crucial for women (Blunden & Flanagan, 2022).

Long-term service provision

A challenge in long-term programme design is the potential undervaluation of the duration of time spent by homeless women without housing while relying on informal networks (Bullen, 2021). Long-term programmes identified in the literature include transitional housing, public housing, the Continuum of Care and Housing First.

Transitional housing serves as a middle ground between emergency shelters and public housing, providing individuals in crisis a place to live for a specific duration, typically 1–2 years (Baker et al., 2010). This period offers greater stability than emergency shelters, although it is shorter than the duration associated with public housing. Spinney and Blandy (2011) suggest that for women, transitional housing in Australia provides

14682397, 2025, 2, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/ijsw.70005, Wiley Online Library on [08/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

greater autonomy and stability as compared to emergency shelters, a benefit that is especially valued by women with children.

Some homeless women are hesitant to live in public housing due to stigma concerns, which may be heightened in women, but they may consider it to be their only option for longer-term housing (Blunden & Flanagan, 2022). However, the public housing provided by the analysed welfare systems fails to meet the existing demand, exacerbating the social housing crisis of recent decades (Flanagan et al., 2019). Despite prioritising single-parent families and female victims of violence in the United States, extensive waiting lists persist, with waiting times extending to months or even years (Keefe & Hahn, 2020). During these waiting periods, many women resort to emergency and transitional housing, although the inadequacy of these temporary resources for women has been evidenced. Some women may be accommodated in temporary private rooms, which may be unsafe for victims of gender-based violence. Although in some situations, temporary and emergency resources may be necessary and positively valued by some homeless women (Netto et al., 2009), others recognise the need for access to more stable housing over time, given the highly stressful situations generated by uncertainty. However, some studies in Canada have indicated that accessing both the public housing market and the social housing sector might be a challenge for these women (Milaney et al., 2020; Schmidt et al., 2015).

The Continuum of Care aims to address chronic homelessness by providing a spectrum of specialised housing facilities and support services for women dealing with homelessness, mental health issues and addictions (Klodawsky, 2009). This strategy guides individuals through a gradual process, transitioning them from emergency shelters to transitional housing and eventually to long-term social housing, receiving targeted interventions for specific challenges. This has proven especially beneficial for pregnant homeless women due to the ongoing monitoring and support that they receive, and for women experiencing mental health issues and substance abuse (Klodawsky, 2009). However, practical implementation may present challenges to coordination and consistency due to resource constraints and service gaps, as highlighted by a study in Australia (Theobald et al., 2023). An issue may arise in which women bear excessive accountability and are expected to meet predetermined behavioural criteria, potentially constraining inclusivity and equity. These predetermined behavioural criteria may be influenced by stereotypical gender conceptions (Fraser et al., 2021; Theobald et al., 2023).

In contrast, the Housing First approach focuses on providing stable housing as a primary step, addressing potential challenges afterwards (Theobald et al., 2023). Unlike other homeless services, it does not mandate specific prerequisites, such as refraining from substance use or undergoing psychiatric treatment (Bullen, 2021). Evaluations in Canada reveal favourable outcomes in housing and mental health, but women have encountered greater difficulties in adaptation as compared to men (Klodawsky, 2009; Yakubovich & Maki, 2021). However, most assessments lack a gender perspective or mainly involve men (Yakubovich & Maki, 2021). Housing First is still in its early stages of implementation in many countries and is not yet widely accessible (Quintana Vigiola et al., 2022). Advantages include increased autonomy and avoiding cohabiting with men in emergency shelters, which may be uncomfortable or unsafe for some women, especially survivors of violence (Murray, 2011). As a result, it may be a more favourable alternative for women (Baker et al., 2010; Bretherton et al., 2016). However, in the case of women, it is crucial to pay more attention to the environment in which they are placed and to ensure that the staff is composed of women who are trained to address women's specific needs (Oudshoorn et al., 2018; Pleace, 2016).

In addition, it reduces state expenses by diminishing the need for emergency resources (Bullen, 2021; Klodawsky, 2009). Concerns persist that Housing First may increase the exclusion of certain women due to its excessive demands for self-sufficiency, given their greater challenges or intensified social isolation (Klodawsky, 2009).

DISCUSSION

This research aimed to identify policies, programmes and strategies concerning homeless women in the academic literature, assess their impact on these women or those at risk of homelessness and explore the challenges that they face within the policy context.

Our findings reveal certain gender-related aspects that should be addressed in homelessness policies, such as gender-based violence, motherhood and differences in physical and mental health between homeless men and women. The studies included in the review highlight a historical emphasis on homeless men in homelessness policies. Despite recent changes, a gender perspective continues to be lacking in homelessness policies. This agrees with the conclusions reached by Minnery and Greenhalgh (2007), which recognised the inadequacy of policies that do not acknowledge the evolving characteristics of homeless populations, including a growing number of homeless women and families, contributing to their social exclusion.

14682397, 2025, 2, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/ijsw.70005, Wiley Online Library on [08/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

The results highlight the challenge of comparing the impact of global welfare policies on reducing homelessness among women. Parsell et al.'s (2012) indicates that transferring and converging homelessness policies between countries highlight the importance of adapting them to local contexts, despite the challenges in implementation.

Addressing homelessness among women

While challenges persist in designing and implementing policies to reduce homelessness and improve the quality of life of women, our research has found certain studies that indicate positive outcomes for homeless women in different contexts.

Preventive policies, such as eviction defence and support for survivors of violence, could play a crucial role in reducing female homelessness. Montgomery et al. (2013) emphasised the importance of early intervention, accurate identification of women at risk and the restructuring of homelessness services for greater autonomy. Internationally adopted strategies to prevent homelessness among victims of gender-based violence are insufficient. Additionally, other potential causes such as mental health issues or addiction problems among women who become homeless should be considered (Bretherton & Mayock, 2021).

While emergency services are essential, instances of resource misuse and shortages of available slots for urgent situations continue to exist. Moreover, the literature (Netto et al., 2009; Vamstad et al., 2022) has revealed a lack of voluntary engagement among women seeking homelessness resources. The qualitative study by Mayock et al. (2015b) with 60 homeless women revealed their reluctance to view homelessness resources as solutions due to centre rules or interactions with professionals. Therefore, establishing safe and supportive spaces for homeless women, recognising their diverse characteristics and vulnerabilities, is essential.

Consequently, our results underscore the need for long-term service provision, including transitional housing, public housing, Continuum of Care and Housing First. Housing First, while offering stable housing as a primary step, presents challenges in terms of adaptation by women. The study by O'Campo et al. (2023), analysing Housing First's effectiveness in a controlled clinical trial among homeless women, revealed improvements in housing stability but no significant differences in mental health and social outcomes. The study by Bassi et al. (2020) with 16 formerly homeless women revealed improved housing stability but no contribution to community integration. Few studies examining Housing First from a gender perspective have acknowledged its limitations, recommending the design of specific programmes for women considering potential cultural and regional factors (O'Campo et al., 2023).

These findings emphasise the shortage of available public housing, leaving women vulnerable and facing long waiting lists. Increasing funding for affordable public housing is crucial for long-term housing security. Some studies (Lawson et al., 2018; Powell et al., 2019; Quintana Vigiola et al., 2022) have shown the benefits of prioritising investment in affordable public housing over financial assistance for private market access. This approach enhances residential stability and economic efficiency, especially when relying on initial capital investments to reduce the need for continuous subsidies.

Programmes and policies for homeless women, such as rapid rehousing and financial support, lose their effectiveness due to the challenges in accessing affordable housing for these women. Advocating for state-level rent control is essential to ensure affordable rental units and increase housing options for vulnerable women (Keefe & Hahn, 2020). However, Cournède et al. (2020) argue that excessive regulation may discourage investment and may limit access to home ownership, suggesting the importance of balanced rent control measures.

Discriminatory policies and eviction measures may have harmful impacts on women, especially for victims of violence. Eviction defence policies play a crucial role in enhancing residential stability and promoting the physical and mental well-being of women (Hatch & Yun, 2020; Robinson & Steil, 2020).

Our findings highlight the lack of recognition of homeless women for those who, after exiting situations of violence or sex work, lack housing and seek refuge in specialised residential services for survivors. These women may not want to be labelled as homeless due to an associated stigma, as indicated by Casey et al. (2008). Other studies have suggested that excluding women housed in violence-related services from homelessness statistics obscures the true extent of the issue among women. This may lead to a perception of female homelessness as being atypical, and this may result in a lack of attention to their specific needs in homelessness policies and services, or it may indicate a lack of coordination between such services, hindering the provision of appropriate interventions to address the problem (Bretherton, 2020; Busch-Geertsema et al., 2010).

The research has revealed an absence of intersectionality in current homelessness policies, emphasising the need for policies that acknowledge the intersection of exclusionary factors such as gender, race and class. Incorporating intersectionality frameworks into policy development challenges power dynamics, acknowledging how

14682397, 2025, 2, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/ijsw.70005, Wiley Online Library on [08/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

identities may add to environmental risks, leading to more inclusive and effective solutions (Cole & Duncan, 2023).

Our findings include insight from both professionals and homeless women, highlighting the frequently overlooked input in the policy-making process. It is imperative to prioritise the development of bottom-up policies. Muraya's (2006) study demonstrated that the bottom-up approach, involving community-based organisations, is more likely to succeed in addressing barriers to the provision of affordable housing as compared to the top-down approach. Crescenzi and Giua (2016) concluded that top-down policies may, in certain instances, be effective in directing resources towards the most socio-economically disadvantaged regions.

In summary, although there have been some successful policies benefiting homeless women, a one-size-fits-all solution does not exist due to the diverse circumstances and dimensions of homelessness. Therefore, policies should be adaptable and aligned with best practices from professionals and service providers. Additionally, good coordination between institutions and resources is essential to ensure comprehensive care for women (O'Brien, 2023).

Study limitations

This study has certain limitations. Firstly, systematic reviews may be influenced by publication bias, where studies with positive results dominate the published literature. Despite our thorough search efforts, certain relevant studies might have been overlooked due to database limitations, restricted access to certain documents or inadequacies in our search terms. Furthermore, while we have conducted our search in three languages, the language criteria may have excluded potentially relevant articles.

Another limitation lies in the fact that few policies specifically targeting homeless women have been identified. The review has focused on policies discussed in the academic literature, but governmental documents, legislative documents or their reviews outside of an academic context have not been considered. Therefore, a proposed future research direction may focus on conducting a review of homelessness policies with a specific gender perspective, specifically considering the grey literature.

Furthermore, the findings are based solely on a few countries, reflecting what has been found in the academic literature. Hence, the majority of the studies included were from high- and middle-income Anglo-Saxon countries, limiting cross-country policy comparisons and broader applicability. Moreover, the characteristics of homelessness in women may vary in other contexts. Therefore, our findings may not directly apply to diverse populations or contexts.

Moreover, long-term impact studies on homelessness policies and comparable quantitative data, especially regarding female homelessness, are lacking, making it difficult to perform a comprehensive analysis.

CONCLUSION

This integrative systematic review integrates various perspectives from politicians, service providers, researchers and homeless women, enriching the examination of homelessness policies assessed in the literature with a gender perspective. Insight from homeless women is crucial to developing bottom-up policies, and the heterogeneity of articles from diverse disciplines promotes interdisciplinarity and enhances research depth. The findings unequivocally underscore the imperative of dedicating efforts to design, implement and assess homelessness policies through a gender-sensitive and intersectional lens.

This study enhances our knowledge of the specific needs of homeless women, the obstacles that they may encounter in accessing social policies and some of the challenges that they may face from a policy perspective. It uncovers the varying impacts of distinct policies and programmes on women and gathers some policy recommendations found in the literature that are aimed at proactively addressing homelessness in a holistic manner, emphasising the integration of a gender-sensitive and intersectional perspective.

For further advances, research should examine the long-term consequences of homelessness policies from a gender perspective. Additionally, future research is needed to evaluate policies for homeless women in countries with different welfare states and diverse socio-economic contexts, in order to gain a comprehensive understanding of their effectiveness and applicability.

Creating inclusive and secure environments tailored to the unique needs of homeless women is crucial for their well-being and empowerment. It is also necessary to conduct a more detailed exploration of the obstacles faced by homeless women in seeking support and to identify potential factors that could help prevent them from remaining in hidden homelessness. By addressing these challenges and implementing gender-sensitive policies, homeless women may be empowered to access social care without hesitation.

14682397, 2025, 2, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/ijsw.70005, Wiley Online Library on [08/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

FUNDING INFORMATION

The author Alba Galán Sanantonio is supported by the Generalitat Valenciana and the European Social Fund under Grant CIACIF 2021/176.

CONFLICT OF INTEREST STATEMENT

The authors declare no conflicts of interest.

DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

Data sharing is not applicable to this article as no new data were created or analyzed in this study.

ORCID

Alba Galán-Sanantonio https://orcid.org/0000-0001-9008-2879
Mercedes Botija https://orcid.org/0000-0002-3414-5529
Ángela Carbonell https://orcid.org/0000-0003-2180-4123

REFERENCES

Alonso, A., Palacios, J., & Iniesta, A. (2020). Mujeres sin hogar en España. Narrativas sobre género, vulnerabilidad social y efectos del entramado asistencial. *OBETS. Revista de Ciencias Sociales*, *15*(2), 375–404.

Atkinson, L., & Cipriani, A. (2018). How to carry out a literature search for a systematic review: A practical guide. *BJPsych Advances*, *24*(2), 74–82. https://doi.org/10.1192/bja.2017.3

Australian Government Department of Social Services. (2021). *Keeping women safe in their homes*. https://www.dss.gov.au/women-programs-services-reducing-violence/keeping-women-safe-in-their-homes

Baker, C. K., Billhardt, K. A., Warren, J. B., Rollins, C., & Glass, N. (2010). Domestic violence, housing instability, and homelessness: A review of housing policies and program practices for meeting the needs of survivors. *Aggression and Violent Behavior*, *15*(6), 430–439. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.avb.2010.07.005

Bassi, A., Sylvestre, J., & Kerman, N. (2020). Finding home: Community integration experiences of formerly homeless women with problematic substance use in Housing First. *Journal of Community Psychology*, *48*(7), 2375–2390. https://doi.org/10.1002/jcop.22423

Benbow, S., Gorlick, C., Forchuk, C., Ward-Griffin, C., & Berman, H. (2016). Ontario's poverty reduction strategy. *Canadian Journal of Nursing Research Archive*, *48*(3–4), 100–109. https://doi.org/10.1177/0844562116684729

Bimpson, E., Green, H., & Reeve, K. (2021). Women, homelessness and violence: What works? https://shura.shu.ac.uk/29412/1/women-homelessness-violence.pdf

Bimpson, E., Parr, S., & Reeve, K. (2020). Governing homeless mothers: The unmaking of home and family. *Housing Studies*, *37*(2), 272–291. https://doi.org/10.1080/02673037.2020.1853069

Blunden, H., & Flanagan, K. (2022). Housing options for women leaving domestic violence: The limitations of rental subsidy models. *Housing Studies*, *37*(10), 1896–1915. https://doi.org/10.1080/02673037.2020.1867711

Bramer, W. M., De Jonge, G. B., Rethlefsen, M. L., Mast, F., & Kleijnen, J. (2018). A systematic approach to searching: An efficient and complete method to develop literature searches. *Journal of the Medical Library Association*, *106*(4), 531–541. https://doi.org/10.5195/jmla.2018.283

Braun, V., & Clarke, V. (2006). Using thematic analysis in psychology. *Qualitative Research in Psychology*, *3*(2), 77–101. https://doi.org/10.1191/1478088706qp063oa

Breckenridge, J., Chung, D., Spinney, A., & Zufferey, C. (2016). National mapping and meta-evaluation outlining key features of effective 'safe at home' programs that enhance safety and prevent homelessness for women and their children experiencing domestic and family violence. Australia's National Research Organisation for Women's Safety (ANROWS). https://www.anrows.org.au/publication/national-mapping-and-meta-evaluation-outlining-key-features-of-effective-safe-at-home-programs-sok/

Bretherton, J., Benjaminsen, L., & Pleace, N. (2016). Women's homelessness and welfare states. In P. Mayock & J. Bretherton (Eds.), *Women's homelessness in Europe* (p. 128). Palgrave Macmillan.

Bretherton, J., & Mayock, P. (2021). Women's homelessness: European evidence review. https://eprints.whiterose.ac.uk/172737/1/FEANTSA_Women_s_Review.pdf

Bretherton, J., & Pleace, N. (2018). *Women and rough sleeping: A critical review of current research and methodology*. University of York.

Bullen, J. (2021). Chronic homelessness - what women's experiences can tell us. *Housing Studies*, *38*(8), 1417–1435. https://doi.org/10.1080/02673037.2021.1941791

Bullock, H. E., Reppond, H. A., Truong, S. V., & Singh, M. R. (2020). An intersectional analysis of the feminization of homelessness and mothers' housing precarity. *Journal of Social Issues*, *76*(4), 835–858. https://doi.org/10.1111/josi.12406

Busch-Geertsema, V., Edgar, W., O'Sullivan, E., & Pleace, N. (2010). Homelessness and homeless policies in Europe: Lessons from research. https://www.feantsa.org/download/fea_020-10_en_final8900978964616628637.pdf

Byrne, T., Treglia, D., Culhane, D. P., Kuhn, J., & Kane, V. (2016). Predictors of homelessness among families and single adults after exit from homelessness prevention and rapid re-housing programs: Evidence from the department of veterans affairs supportive services for veteran families program. *Housing Policy Debate*, *26*(1), 252–275. https://doi.org/10.1080/10511482.2015.1060249

Casey, R., Goudie, R., & Reeve, K. (2008). Homeless women in public spaces: Strategies of resistance. *Housing Studies*, *23*(6), 899–916. https://doi.org/10.1080/02673030802416627

Cheng, A.-L., & Kelly, P. J. (2008). Impact of an integrated service system on client outcomes by gender in a national sample of a mentally ill homeless population. *Gender Medicine*, *5*(4), 395–404. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.genm.2008.10.003

Cole, E. R., & Duncan, L. E. (2023). Better policy interventions through intersectionality. *Social Issues and Policy Review*, *7*(1), 62–78. https://doi.org/10.1111/sipr.12090

Cournède, B., Ziemann, V., & De Pace, F. (2020). *The Future of Housing: Policy Scenarios*. OECD Economics Department Working Papers, No. 1624. OECD Publishing, https://doi.org/10.1787/0adf02cb-en.

Cramer, H. (2005). Informal and gendered practices in a homeless persons unit. *Housing Studies*, *20*(5), 737–751. https://doi.org/10.1080/02673030500213987

14682397, 2025, 2, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/jjsw.70005, Wiley Online Library on [08/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

Crescenzi, R., & Giua, M. (2016). The EU Cohesion Policy in context: Does a bottom-up approach work in all regions? *Environment and Planning A: Economy and Space*, *48*(11), 2340–2357. https://doi.org/10.1177/0308518X16658291

Critical Appraisal Skills Programme. (2023a). CASP qualitative studies checklist. https://casp-uk.net/checklists/casp-qualitative-studies-checklist-fillable.pdf

Critical Appraisal Skills Programme. (2023b). CASP systematic review checklist. https://casp-uk.net/checklists/casp-systematic-review-checklist-fillable.pdf

Cronin, M. A., & George, E. (2020). The why and how of the integrative review. *Organizational Research Methods*, *26*(1), 161–192. https://doi.org/10.1177/1094428120935507

Da Costa, S. L., Da Costa Vida, C. P., Gama, I. A., Locatelli, N. T., Karam, B. J., Ping, C. T., Massari, M. G., De Paula, T. B., & Bernardes, A. F. M. (2015). Gestantes em situação de rua no município de Santos, SP: reflexões e desafios para as políticas públicas. *Saude e Sociedade*, *24*(3), 1089–1102. https://doi.org/10.1590/s0104-12902015134769

Desmond, M. (2014). Poor Black women are evicted at alarming rates, setting off a chain of hardship. Policy Research Brief. MacArthur Foundation. https://www.macfound.org/media/files/HHM_Research_Brief_-_Poor_Black_Women_Are_Evicted_at_Alarming_Rates.pdf

Desmond, M., & Valdez, N. (2012). Unpolicing the urban poor. *American Sociological Review*, *78*(1), 117–141. https://doi.org/10.1177/0003122412470829

Eriksen, M. B., & Frandsen, T. F. (2018). The impact of patient, intervention, comparison, outcome (PICO) as a search strategy tool on literature search quality: A systematic review. *Journal of the Medical Library Association*, *106*(4), 420–431. https://doi.org/10.5195/jmla.2018.345

FEANTSA. (2007). European typology of homelessness and housing exclusion. http://www.feantsa.org

Flanagan, K., Blunden, H., Valentine, K., & Henriette, J. (2019). Housing outcomes after domestic and family violence. AHURI Final Report, 311. https://doi.org/10.18408/ahuri-4116101.

Fraser, B., White, M., Cook, H., Chisholm, E., Ombler, J., Chun, S., Tareha, H., & Pierse, N. (2021). Service usage of a cohort of formerly homeless women in Aotearoa New Zealand. *SSM-Population Health*, *15*, 100842. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ssmph.2021.100842

Hatch, M., & Yun, J. (2020). Losing your home is bad for your health: Short- and medium-term health effects of eviction on young adults. *Housing Policy Debate*, *31*, 469–489. https://doi.org/10.1080/10511482.2020.1812690

Hong, Q. N., Fàbregues, S., Bartlett, G., Boardman, F., Cargo, M., Dagenais, P., Gagnon, M. P., Griffiths, F., Nicolau, B., O'Cathain, A., Rousseau, M. C., Vedel, I., & Pluye, P. (2018). The mixed methods appraisal tool (MMAT) version 2018 for information professionals and researchers. *Education for Information*, *34*(4), 285–291. https://doi.org/10.3233/EFI-180221

Jones, M., & Wendt, S. (2022). Developing an intake assessment for domestic and family violence supported accommodation. *Australian Social Work*, *77*(2), 1–15. https://doi.org/10.1080/0312407x.2022.2105161

Katz, A. S., Zerger, S., & Hwang, S. W. (2017). Housing first the conversation: Discourse, policy and the limits of the possible. *Critical Public Health*, *27*(1), 139–147. https://doi.org/10.1080/09581596.2016.1167838

Keefe, R., & Hahn, S. A. (2020). Policy roles in promoting affordable housing for survivors of intimate partner violence. *Violence against Women*, *27*(9), 1317–1336. https://doi.org/10.1177/1077801220913629

Klodawsky, F. (2009). Home spaces and rights to the city: Thinking social justice for chronically homeless women. *Urban Geography*, *30*(6), 591–610. https://doi.org/10.2747/0272-3638.30.6.591

Lawson, J., Pawson, H., Troy, L., van den Nouwelant, R., & Hamilton, C. (2018). Social housing as infrastructure: An investment pathway. https://www.ahuri.edu.au/sites/default/files/migration/documents/AHURI-Final-Report-306-Social-housing-as-infrastructure-an-investment-pathway.pdf

Lim, Y., Andersen, R., Leake, B., Cunningham, W., & Gelberg, L. (2002). How accessible is medical care for homeless women? *Medical Care*, *40*, 510–520. https://doi.org/10.1097/00005650-200206000-00008

Lima, N., Souza, R., Feitosa, P., Moreira, J., Silva, C., & Neto, M. (2020). People experiencing homelessness: Their potential exposure to COVID-19. *Psychiatry Research*, *288*, 112945. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.psychres.2020.112945

Löfstrand, C., & Quilgars, D. (2016). Cultural images and definitions of homeless women: Implications for policy and practice at the European level. In P. Mayock & J. Bretherton (Eds.), *Women's homelessness in Europe* (p. 128). Palgrave Macmillan.

Mayock, P., Sheridan, S., & Parker, S. (2015a). 'It's just like we're going around in circles and going back to the same thing …': The dynamics of Women's unresolved homelessness. *Housing Studies*, *30*(6), 877–900. https://doi.org/10.1080/02673037.2014.991378

Mayock, P., Sheridan, S., & Parker, S. (2015b). *The dynamics of long-term homelessness among women in Ireland*. Dublin Region Homeless Executive. https://www.drugsandalcohol.ie/24776/1/Mayock-et-al-2015-The-dynamics-of-long-term-homelessness-among-women-in-Ireland.pdf

Mayock, P., & Bretheron, J. (Eds.). (2016). *Women's homelessness in Europe*. Palgrave Macmillan. https://doi.org/10.1057/978-1-137-54516-9"

Milaney, K., Tremblay, R., Bristowe, S. K., & Ramage, K. (2020). Welcome to Canada: Why are family emergency shelters 'home' for recent newcomers? *Societies*, *10*(2), 37. https://doi.org/10.3390/soc10020037

Minayo, M. C. (2004). *Pesquisa social: Teoria, método e criatividade*. Vozes.

Minnery, J., & Greenhalgh, E. (2007). Approaches to homelessness policy in Europe, the United States, and Australia. *Journal of Social Issues*, *63*(3), 641–655. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1540-4560.2007.00528.x

Mitchell, E., Waring, T., Ahern, E., O'Donovan, D., Bradley, D., & Bradley, D. (2023). Predictors and consequences of homelessness in whole-population observational studies that used administrative data: A systematic review. *BMC Public Health*, *23*(1), 1–12. https://doi.org/10.1186/s12889-023-16503-z

Montgomery, A. E., Metraux, S., & Culhane, D. P. (2013). Rethinking homelessness prevention among persons with serious mental illness. *Social Issues and Policy Review*, *7*(1), 58–82. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1751-2409.2012.01043.x

14682397, 2025, 2, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/jsw.70005, Wiley Online Library on [08/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

Mostowska, M. (2021). The welfare state and the gender dissimilarity index in homelessness: A comparison of Norway, Belgium and Poland. *Critical Housing Analysis*, *8*(1), 11–23. https://doi.org/10.13060/23362839.2021.8.1.519

Mostowska, M., & Dębska, K. (2020). An ambiguous hierarchy of inequalities. The political intersectionality of older women's homelessness in Poland. *Journal of Gender Studies*, *29*(4), 443–456. https://doi.org/10.1080/09589236.2020.1716699

Muraya, P. (2006). Failed top-down policies in housing: The cases of Nairobi and Santo Domingo. *Cities*, *23*, 121–128. https://doi.org/10.1016/J.CITIES.2005.08.002

Murray, S. (2011). Violence against homeless women: Safety and social policy. *Australian Social Work*, *64*(3), 346–360. https://doi.org/10.1080/0312407x.2011.552983

Nardes, S., & Giongo, C. R. (2021). Mulheres em situação de rua: memórias, cotidiano e acesso às políticas públicas. *Revista Estudos Feministas*, *29*(1). https://doi.org/10.1590/1806-9584-2021v29n166011

Netto, G., Pawson, H., & Sharp, C. (2009). Preventing homelessness due to domestic violence: Providing a safe space or closing the door to new possibilities? *Social Policy & Administration*, *43*(7), 719–735. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9515.2009.00691.x

O'Brien, A. (2023). Homelessness as a feminist issue: Revisiting the 1970s. *Australian Feminist Studies*, *37*(112), 134–151. https://doi.org/10.1080/08164649.2023.2173140

O'Campo, P., Nisenbaum, R., Crocker, A. G., Nicholls, T., Eiboff, F., & Adair, C. E. (2023). Women experiencing homelessness and mental illness in a housing first multi-site trial: Looking beyond housing to social outcomes and well-being. *PLoS One*, *18*(2), e0277074. https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0277074

Oudshoorn, A., Forchuk, C., Hall, J., Smith-Carrier, T., & Van Berkum, A. (2018). An evaluation of a housing first program for chronically homeless women. *Journal of Social Inclusion*, *9*(2), 34–50. https://doi.org/10.36251/josi.136

Paez, A. (2017). Grey literature: An important resource in systematic reviews. *Journal of Evidence-Based Medicine*, *10*, 133–240. https://doi.org/10.1111/jebm.12266

Page, M. J., McKenzie, J. E., Bossuyt, P. M., Boutron, I., Hoffmann, T., Mulrow, C. D., Shamseer, L., Tetzlaff, J., Akl, E. A., Brennan, S., Chou, R., Glanville, J., Grimshaw, J., Hróbjartsson, A., Lalu, M. M., Li, T., Loder, E., Mayo-Wilson, E., McDonald, S., & Moher, D. (2021). The PRISMA 2020 statement: An updated guideline for reporting systematic reviews. *Systematic Reviews*, *10*(1), 1–11. https://doi.org/10.1186/s13643-021-01626-4

Parsell, C., Jones, A., & Head, B. (2012). Policies and programmes to end homelessness in Australia: Learning from international practice. *International Journal of Social Welfare*, *22*(2), 186–194. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1468-2397.2012.00884.x

Perri, M., & O'Campo, P. (2021). A gap in knowledge surrounding urban housing interventions: A call for gender redistribution. *Health Promotion International*, *36*(4), 908–912. https://doi.org/10.1093/heapro/daab062

Pleace, N. (2016). Housing First Guide Europe. https://www.feantsa.org/download/hfg_full_digital1907983494259831639.pdf

Powell, A., Meltzer, A., Martin, C., Stone, W., Liu, E., Flanagan, K., Muir, K., & Tually, S. (2019). *A pathway to where? Inquiry into understanding and reimagining social housing pathways* (Final Report (Vol. No. 316)). Australian Housing and Urban Research Institute. https://doi.org/10.18408/ahuri-7118101

Quintana Vigiola, G., Donnelly, S., & Wan, K. (2022). Housing provision for women experiencing domestic and family violence in NSW during COVID-19. *Urban Policy and Research*, *40*(1), 1–15. https://doi.org/10.1080/08111146.2022.2122426

Reeve, K., & Bimpson, E. (2020). Forgotten mothers: the case for a policy focus on the experiences of motherhood and homelessness. https://shura.shu.ac.uk/27627/9/Reeve-ForgottenMothersCase%28VoR%29.pdf

Reppond, H. A., & Bullock, H. E. (2018). Framing homeless policy: Reducing cash aid as a compassionate solution. *Analyses of Social Issues and Public Policy*, *18*(1), 284–306. https://doi.org/10.1111/asap.12156

Robinson, D., & Steil, J. (2020). Eviction dynamics in market-rate multifamily rental housing. *Housing Policy Debate*, *31*, 647–669. https://doi.org/10.1080/10511482.2020.1839936

Rodriguez-Moreno, S., Panadero, S., & Vázquez, J. (2020). Risk of mental ill-health among homeless women in Madrid (Spain). *Archives of Women's Mental Health*, *23*, 1–8. https://doi.org/10.1007/s00737-020-01036-w

Schmidt, R. A., Hrenchuk, C., Bopp, J., & Poole, N. (2015). Trajectories of women's homelessness in Canada's 3 northern territories. *International Journal of Circumpolar Health*, *74*(1), 29778. https://doi.org/10.3402/ijch.v74.29778

Shinn, M. (2010). Is violence at the root of homelessness for women? *Sex Roles*, *64*(7–8), 585–588. https://doi.org/10.1007/s11199-010-9898-8

Sisco, T. S. (2017). Gender and policy implementation: Analyzing and predicting the progress of congressional bills targeting homeless women, 1977–1987. *Journal of Women, Politics & Policy*, *38*(3), 385–408. https://doi.org/10.1080/1554477x.2016.1219596

Song, J. (2008). The making of 'undeserving' homeless women: A gendered analysis of homeless policy in South Korea from 1997 to 2001. *Feminist Review*, *89*, 87–101.

Spinney, A. (2012). Home and safe? Policy and practice innovations to prevent women and children who have experienced domestic and family violence from becoming homeless (AHURI Final Report No. 196). Australian Housing and Urban Research Institute, Swinburne Research Centre.

Spinney, A., & Blandy, S. (2011). Homelessness prevention for women and children who have experienced domestic and family violence: Innovations in policy and practice (AHURI Positioning Paper No. 140). Australian Housing and Urban Research Institute, Swinburne–Monash Research Centre. https://www.ahuri.edu.au/sites/default/files/migration/documents/AHURI_Positioning_Paper_No140_Homelessness-prevention-for-women-and-children-who-have-experienced-domestic-and-family-violence-innovations.pdf

Theobald, J., Watson, J., Hayett, F., & Murray, S. (2023). Supporting pregnant women experiencing homelessness. *Australian Social Work*, *76*(1), 34–46. https://doi.org/10.1080/0312407x.2022.2107433

Torraco, R. J. (2016). Writing integrative literature reviews. *Human Resource Development Review*, *15*(4), 404–428. https://doi.org/10.1177/1534484316671606

Vamstad, J., Mattsson, E., & Klarare, A. (2022). Social rights and street-level services for women in homelessness: A qualitative

14682397, 2025, 2, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/jsw.70005, Wiley Online Library on [08/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

study. *Nordic Social Work Research*, *14*(4), 1–13. https://doi.org/10.1080/2156857x.2022.2132529

VERBI Software. (2020). MAXQDA analytics Pro 2020 [Software]. VERBISoftware https://www.maxqda.com

Willie, T. C., Linton, S. L., Whittaker, S., Martinez, I., Sharpless, L., & Kershaw, T. (2021). "There's no place like home": Examining the associations between state eviction defense protections and indicators of biopsychosocial stress among survivors of intimate partner violence. *Social Science & Medicine*, *279*, 113957. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.socscimed.2021.113957

Wolf, J., Anderson, I., van den Dries, L., & Filipovič Hrast, M. (2016). The health of homeless women. In P. Mayock & J. Bretherton (Eds.), *Women's homelessness in Europe* (pp. 155–178). Palgrave Macmillan. https://doi.org/10.1057/978-1-137-54516-9

Yakubovich, A. R., & Maki, K. (2021). Preventing gender-based homelessness in Canada during the COVID-19 pandemic and beyond: The need to account for violence against women. *Violence against Women*, *28*(10), 2587–2599. https://doi.org/10.1177/10778012211034202

Yohannes, K., Målqvist, M., Bradby, H., Berhane, Y., & Van Wees, S. H. (2023). Addressing the needs of Ethiopia's street homeless women of reproductive age in the health and social protection policy: A qualitative study. *International Journal for Equity in Health*, *22*(1), 80. https://doi.org/10.1186/s12939-023-01874-x

How to cite this article: Galán-Sanantonio, A., Botija, M., & Carbonell, Á. (2025). A systematic integrative review of international policies for women experiencing homelessness. *International Journal of Social Welfare*, *34*(3), e70005. https://doi.org/10.1111/ijsw.70005

14682397, 2025, 2, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/ijsw.70005, Wiley Online Library on [08/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

APPENDIX A: SYSTEMATIC INTEGRATIVE REVIEW OF INTERNATIONAL POLICIES FOR WOMEN EXPERIENCING HOMELESSNESS

TABLE A1 PRISMA 2020 checklist.

Section and topic	Item no.	Checklist item	Location where item is reported
Title			
Title	1	Identify the report as a systematic review.	1
Abstract			
Abstract	2	See the PRISMA 2020 for Abstracts checklist.	1
Introduction			
Rationale	3	Describe the rationale for the review in the context of existing knowledge.	2–4
Objectives	4	Provide an explicit statement of the objective(s) or question(s) the review addresses.	4
Methods			
Eligibility criteria	5	Specify the inclusion and exclusion criteria for the review and how studies were grouped for the syntheses.	6
Information sources	6	Specify all databases, registers, websites, organisations, reference lists and other sources searched or consulted to identify studies. Specify the date when each source was last searched or consulted.	5–6
Search strategy	7	Present the full search strategies for all databases, registers and websites, including any filters and limits used.	5–6
Selection process	8	Specify the methods used to decide whether a study met the inclusion criteria of the review, including how many reviewers screened each record and each report retrieved, whether they worked independently, and if applicable, details of automation tools used in the process.	7–8
Data collection process	9	Specify the methods used to collect data from reports, including how many reviewers collected data from each report, whether they worked independently, any processes for obtaining or confirming data from study investigators, and if applicable, details of automation tools used in the process.	7–8
Data items	10a	List and define all outcomes for which data were sought. Specify whether all results that were compatible with each outcome domain in each study were sought (e.g., for all measures, time points, analyses), and if not, the methods used to decide which results to collect.	-
	10b	List and define all other variables for which data were sought (e.g., participant and intervention characteristics, funding sources). Describe any assumptions made about any missing or unclear information.	5–8
Study risk of bias assessment	11	Specify the methods used to assess risk of bias in the included studies, including details of the tool(s) used, how many reviewers assessed each study and whether they worked independently, and if applicable, details of automation tools used in the process.	8
Effect measures	12	Specify for each outcome the effect measure(s) (e.g., risk ratio, mean difference) used in the synthesis or presentation of results.	-
Synthesis methods	13a	Describe the processes used to decide which studies were eligible for each synthesis (e.g., tabulating the study intervention characteristics and comparing against the planned groups for each synthesis (item No. 5).	-
	13b	Describe any methods required to prepare the data for presentation or synthesis, such as handling of missing summary statistics, or data conversions.	-

14682397, 2025, 2, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/ijsw.70005, Wiley Online Library on [08/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

TABLE A1 (Continued)

Section and topic	Item no.	Checklist item	Location where item is reported
	13c	Describe any methods used to tabulate or visually display results of individual studies and syntheses.	-
	13d	Describe any methods used to synthesise results and provide a rationale for the choice(s). If meta-analysis was performed, describe the model(s), method(s) to identify the presence and extent of statistical heterogeneity and software package(s) used.	-
	13e	Describe any methods used to explore possible causes of heterogeneity among study results (e.g., subgroup analysis, meta-regression).	-
	13f	Describe any sensitivity analyses conducted to assess robustness of the synthesised results.	-
Reporting bias assessment	14	Describe any methods used to assess risk of bias due to missing results in a synthesis (arising from reporting biases).	-
Certainty assessment	15	Describe any methods used to assess certainty (or confidence) in the body of evidence for an outcome.	-
Results			
Study selection	16a	Describe the results of the search and selection process, from the number of records identified in the search to the number of studies included in the review, ideally using a flow diagram.	Figure 1
	16b	Cite studies that might appear to meet the inclusion criteria, but which were excluded, and explain why they were excluded.	-
Study characteristics	17	Cite each included study and present its characteristics.	Table 1
Risk of bias in studies	18	Present assessments of risk of bias for each included study.	Table 1
Results of individual studies	19	For all outcomes, present, for each study: (a) summary statistics for each group (where appropriate) and (b) an effect estimate and its precision (e.g., confidence/credible interval), ideally using structured tables or plots.	-
Results of syntheses	20a	For each synthesis, briefly summarise the characteristics and risk of bias among contributing studies.	Table 1
	20b	Present results of all statistical syntheses conducted. If meta-analysis was done, present for each the summary estimate and its precision (e.g., confidence/credible interval) and measures of statistical heterogeneity. If comparing groups, describe the direction of the effect.	-
	20c	Present results of all investigations of possible causes of heterogeneity among study results.	-
	20d	Present results of all sensitivity analyses conducted to assess the robustness of the synthesised results.	-
Reporting biases	21	Present assessments of risk of bias due to missing results (arising from reporting biases) for each synthesis assessed.	-
Certainty of evidence	22	Present assessments of certainty (or confidence) in the body of evidence for each outcome assessed.	-
Discussion			
Discussion	23a	Provide a general interpretation of the results in the context of other evidence.	22–26
	23b	Discuss any limitations of the evidence included in the review.	26
	23c	Discuss any limitations of the review processes used.	26
	23d	Discuss implications of the results for practice, policy and future research.	27

(Continues)

14682397, 2025, 2, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/ijsw.70005, Wiley Online Library on [08/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

TABLE A1 (Continued)

Section and topic	Item no.	Checklist item	Location where item is reported
Other information			
Registration and protocol	24a	Provide registration information for the review, including register name and registration number, or state that the review was not registered.	-
	24b	Indicate where the review protocol can be accessed, or state that a protocol was not prepared.	-
	24c	Describe and explain any amendments to information provided at registration or in the protocol.	-
Support	25	Describe sources of financial or non-financial support for the review, and the role of the funders or sponsors in the review.	1
Competing interests	26	Declare any competing interests of review authors.	1
Availability of data, code and other materials	27	Report which of the following are publicly available and where they can be found: template data collection forms; data extracted from included studies; data used for all analyses; analytic code; any other materials used in the review.	1

Note: For more information, visit: http://www.prisma-statement.org/.
Source: Page et al. (2021).

TABLE A2 PRISMA 2020 for abstracts checklist.

Section and topic	Item no.	Checklist item	Reported (yes/no)
Title			
Title	1	Identify the report as a systematic review.	Yes
Background			
Objectives	2	Provide an explicit statement of the main objective(s) or question(s) the review addresses.	Yes
Methods			
Eligibility criteria	3	Specify the inclusion and exclusion criteria for the review.	Yes
Information sources	4	Specify the information sources (e.g., databases, registers) used to identify studies and the date when each was last searched.	Yes
Risk of bias	5	Specify the methods used to assess risk of bias in the included studies.	Yes
Synthesis of results	6	Specify the methods used to present and synthesise results.	Yes
Results			
Included studies	7	Give the total number of included studies and participants and summarise relevant characteristics of studies.	Yes
Synthesis of results	8	Present results for main outcomes, preferably indicating the number of included studies and participants for each. If meta-analysis was done, report the summary estimate and confidence/credible interval. If comparing groups, indicate the direction of the effect (i.e., which group is favoured).	Yes
Discussion			
Limitations of evidence	9	Provide a brief summary of the limitations of the evidence included in the review (e.g., study risk of bias, inconsistency and imprecision).	Yes
Interpretation	10	Provide a general interpretation of the results and important implications.	Yes
Other			
Funding	11	Specify the primary source of funding for the review.	Yes
Registration	12	Provide the register name and registration number.	-

Source: Page et al. (2021).

14682397, 2025, 2, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/ijsw.70005, Wiley Online Library on [08/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

TABLE A3 Quality assessment for studies using qualitative methods and reviews—CASP.

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	Score	Quality
Qualitative methods[a]												
Benbow et al. (2016)	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	C	N	Y	Y	Y	8	High
Bimpson et al. (2020)	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	10	High
Blunden and Flanagan (2022)	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	N	N	Y	Y	Y	8	High
Bullen (2021)	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	C	Y	Y	Y	Y	9	High
Bullock et al. (2020)	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	10	High
Cramer (2005)	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	N	Y	Y	Y	9	High
Da Costa et al. (2015)	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	10	High
Jones and Wendt (2022)	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	10	High
Milaney et al. (2020)	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	C	C	Y	Y	Y	8	High
Mostowska and Dębska (2020)	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	10	High
Murray (2011)	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	10	High
Nardes and Giongo (2021)	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	C	Y	Y	Y	Y	9	High
Oudshoorn et al. (2018)	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	10	High
Schmidt et al. (2015)	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	10	High
Song (2008)	Y	Y	Y	C	Y	N	N	Y	Y	Y	7	Moderate
Theobald et al. (2023)	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	10	High
Vamstad et al. (2022)	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	10	High
Quintana Vigiola et al. (2022)	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	10	High
Yohannes et al. (2023)	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	10	High
Review methods[b]												
Baker et al. (2010)	Y	C	N	N	Y	Y	Y	C	C	Y	5	Moderate
Benbow et al. (2016)	Y	Y	Y	C	Y	Y	Y	Y	C	Y	8	High
Jones & Wendt, 2022	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	10	High
Keefe and Hahn (2020)	Y	Y	C	C	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	8	High
Klodawsky (2009)	Y	C	N	N	Y	Y	Y	Y	C	Y	6	Moderate
Mostowska (2021)	Y	Y	C	C	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	8	High
O'Brien (2023)	Y	N	N	N	Y	Y	Y	Y	C	Y	6	Moderate
Perri and O'Campo (2021)	Y	C	C	N	Y	Y	C	Y	C	Y	5	Moderate
Yakubovich and Maki (2021)	Y	C	C	C	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	7	Moderate

Note: Y, yes; N, no; C, can't tell.

[a]CASP Qualitative Studies Checklist: (1) Was there a clear statement of the aims of the research? (2) Is a qualitative methodology appropriate? (3) Was the research design appropriate to address the aims of the research? (4) Was the recruitment strategy appropriate to the aims of the research? (5) Was the data collected in a way that addressed the research issue? (6) Has the relationship between researcher and participants been adequately considered? (7) Have ethical issues been taken into consideration? (8) Was the data analysis sufficiently rigorous? (9) Is there a clear statement of findings? (10) How valuable is the research?

[b]CASP Systematic Review Checklist: (1) Did the review address a clearly focused question? (2) Did the authors look for the right type of papers? (3) Do you think all the important, relevant studies were included? (4) Did the review's authors do enough to assess quality of the included studies? (5) If the results of the review have been combined, was it reasonable to do so? (6) What are the overall results of the review? (7) How precise are the results? (8) Can the results be applied to the local population? (9) Were all important outcomes considered? (10) Are the benefits worth the harms and costs?

14682397, 2025, 2, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/ijsw.70005, Wiley Online Library on [08/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

TABLE A4 Quality assessment for studies using quantitative methods and mixed methods—MMAT.

	Cheng and Kelly (2008)	Fraser et al. (2021)	Netto et al. (2009)	Sisco (2017)	Willie et al. (2021)
Screening questions (for all types)					
S.1 Are there clear research questions?	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
S.2 Do the collected data allow to address the research questions?	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
1. Qualitative					
1.1. Is the qualitative approach appropriate to answer the research question	-	-	Y	-	-
1.2. Are the qualitative data collection methods adequate to address the research question?	-	-	Y	-	-
1.3. Are the findings adequately derived from the data?	-	-	Y	-	-
1.4. Is the interpretation of results sufficiently substantiated by data?	-	-	Y	-	-
1.5. Is there coherence between qualitative data sources, collection, analysis and interpretation	-	-	Y	-	-
3. Quantitative non-randomised					
3.1 Are the participants representative of the target population?	Y	-	-	-	-
3.2 Are measurements appropriate regarding both the outcome and intervention (or exposure)?	Y	-	-	-	-
3.3 Are there complete outcome data?	Y	-	-	-	-
3.4 Are the confounders accounted for in the design and analysis?	Y	-	-	-	-
3.5 During the study period, is the intervention administered (or exposure occurred) as intended?	C	-	-	-	-
4. Quantitative descriptive					
4.1 Is the sampling strategy relevant to address the research question?	-	Y	Y	Y	Y
4.2 Is the sample representative of the target population?	-	Y	Y	Y	Y
4.3 Are the measurements appropriate?	-	Y	C	Y	Y
4.4 Is the risk of non-response bias low?	-	C	C	C	C
4.5 Is the statistical analysis appropriate to answer the research question?	-	Y	Y	C	Y
5. Mixed methods					
5.1 Is there an adequate rationale for using a mixed-methods design to address the research question?	-	-	Y	-	-
5.2 Are the different components of the study effectively integrated to answer the research question?	-	-	Y	-	-
5.3 Are the outputs of the integration of qualitative and quantitative components adequately interpreted?	-	-	Y	-	-
5.4 Are divergences and inconsistencies between quantitative and qualitative results adequately addressed?	-	-	Y	-	-
5.5 Do the different components of the study adhere to the quality criteria of each tradition of the methods involved?	-	-	Y	-	-
Score	8.6	8,6	8.8	7.1	8.6
Quality	High	High	High	Moderate	High

Note: Y, yes; N, no; C, can't tell.
Source: Hong et al. (2018).

14682397, 2025, 2, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/ijsw.70005, Wiley Online Library on [08/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License